



and there will be further improvements going into next year.

You've always been associated with timing and elegance. How challenging is it to be a three-format player in modern cricket?

It is challenging. I played almost the entire domestic season last year and a lot of red-ball cricket as well.

From the fifth IPL game I played in 2025 to the first game of IPL 2026, I had played just one T20 during that period. It does make a difference when you spend so much time playing one particular format.

Generally, the best T20 players play a lot of that format and have plenty of matches under their belt. So it is a difficult shift.

But as a three-format player, it is a privilege to be part of every squad and every format. As long as I feel ready to compete in all three, it's about adjusting and adapting to

what each format demands.

T20 cricket is evolving. One-day cricket is changing as well. You have to evolve with it.

Has the IPL redefined batting, especially in terms of risk-taking?

When you see these kinds of PowerPlay scores, it's exciting as a batter. As a bowler, it might feel a little different. It's always good to have runs on the board, irrespective of the format you're playing. Ultimately, runs determine the outcome of a match.

That said, there's undoubtedly a slight imbalance between bat and ball. Batting has become a little easier with things like the Impact Player rule.

Has captaincy changed you as a batter?

Whether I am captain or not, I don't think there has been any major change in my mindset or approach.

Mixed returns: Ruturaj's measured leadership, shaped by M. S. Dhoni's philosophy of keeping things simple, helped Chennai Super Kings fight through setbacks and stay in the playoff race until the very end. R. RAGU

A message for CSK fans?

Just be patient. We've seen some of the best days over the last 14 or 15 years, and we still believe we are one of the best franchises in the IPL.

There will always be ups and downs. Supporting every player who represents CSK is important. Everyone who plays for CSK feels something special about representing the franchise and wants to do a little more for the team.

Sometimes things don't work out the way we want them to. But every player is working hard to get the team back to where the fans want to see it. Hopefully, we'll get there.